



Statues adorn the Meenakshi Temple in Madurai, India. Originally constructed by Kulasekhara Pandya, the temple was destroyed by Muslim invaders and later rebuilt.

IN SOUTHERN INDIA, KING KULASEKHARA I (r. 1268–1308) expanded the empire of the **Pandya**s to its greatest extent. The Pandya were an ancient **Tamil** people of the far south, who contended for supremacy over the centuries with neighboring kingdoms such as the **Cholas** and the island of **Ceylon** (Sri Lanka). Under **Sundara** (r. 1251–68) the Pandya empire had expanded dramatically and reduced some neighboring states to vassalage. His son **Kulasekhara** went on to conquer Kerala, Kongu, and Ceylon, and in 1279 he defeated the last **Chola** king, **Rajendra III**, and annexed his territories. The

Divine wind

An engraving shows the destruction of the Mongol fleet by the *kamikaze* ("divine wind") in 1281.

greatness of the Pandya court was attested to by Venetian merchant **Marco Polo**, who would pass through in 1293, but the empire was short-lived, breaking up in the early 14th century due to family quarrels and **Muslim invasions**.

By the late 13th century, the **Maori** had settled in **New Zealand** (with the exception of Antarctica, the last land mass to be colonized by humans). Dating the Maori colonization is contentious. According to estimates based on Maori traditions, the first **Polynesians** visited the islands in the early 10th century, and waves of colonization climaxed with the arrival of the **Great Fleet** of ocean-going canoes in 1350. Archaeological findings tell a slightly different story. However, it seems likely that Polynesians, probably from **Tahiti**, arrived in

New Zealand around 1280, dividing the territory between **hapu** (clans). Hapu that traced a common ancestry formed **iwi** (tribes), some of which could trace their lineage back to a single **waka houra** (ocean-going canoe).

Having conquered Korea and most of China, **Kublai Khan** (1215–94) set his sights on **Japan**, sending embassies demanding submission as early as 1268. Under the bold leadership of the **Hojo regency**, the Japanese refused to be cowed. After a failed invasion attempt in 1274, Kublai sent **150,000 men** in two huge fleets in 1281, but the Japanese held off the invading armada until a great typhoon, known in Japan as the **kamikaze** ("divine wind"), devastated the Mongol fleet.

MAORI CARVING

Maori culture is noted for its tradition of arts and crafts; chief among these is *te toi whakairo* (carving). Master craftsmen were believed to channel the voices of the spirits and ancestors, and intricately carved posts and lintels adorning structures around the *marae* (sacred space) and *waka* (canoes) were believed to accumulate and pass on *mana* (spiritual power).



Guglielmo Berardi da Narbona was killed at the Battle of Campaldino.

IN THE 1280S, A TRIBE OF TURKOMAN NOMADIC HORSEMEN and raiders based in northwestern Anatolia, known as the **Ottomans**, elected **Osman** (1258–1354) as their chieftain. At this time, the political map of Anatolia was fractured: the Mongol onslaught had broken up Seljuk Rum and replaced it with many small principalities, while also driving waves of Muslim refugees into the region. Meanwhile, the **Byzantine Empire** had been successively **reduced** and broken up by Seljuk and Latin encroachment. Osman was able to lead his tribe in a **territorial expansion**, rapidly conquering Byzantine territory.

Florence, like many other Italian cities, had developed into a largely **autonomous republic** or commune. It was typically easier for the German emperors—the notional feudal overlords—to grant cities powers of self-government than try to control them directly. Since the mid-13th century, Florence had seen sawed violently between **Guelph** and **Ghibelline** regimes (see 1221–25). This **Guelph–Ghibelline** conflict had gripped the Italian city-states, providing a vehicle for the expression of local **class tensions** as well as national and international politics. When one faction gained the upper hand in a city, the other was typically expelled. In the 1280s, the Guelphs had the upper hand, and Guelph partisans exiled from Arezzo encouraged them to take up arms against the rival city. The Florentines defeated Arezzo at the



1276 Treaty of Vienna: Rudolf I of Germany makes Vienna the capital of Hapsburg lands

1278 Otto Visconti comes to power in Milan

1279 Formation of the Guelph Tuscan League

1279 Kublai Khan completes the conquest of Southern Song by destroying their fleet at Macau

c. 1280s Osman elected chieftain by Turkoman tribesmen; Ottoman dynasty founded

1281 Under the influence of Charles of Anjou, Pope Martin IV renounces the union of Byzantine and Roman churches

1282 Sicilian Vespers: Revolt against Angevin rule; Sicily is offered to Peter III of Aragon

1284 Genoa fleet defeats Angevin navy off Naples, and destroys the Pisan fleet off Meloria

1285 Having completed the conquest of Prussia, Teutonic Knights begin an assault on Lithuania

1286 Kublai Khan's army defeated by Dai Viet; he abandons plans to invade Japan

c. 1286 Compilation of the Zohar (a collection of Jewish Kabbalah literature)

1287 Kublai Khan's army destroys Pagan Empire (present-day Burma)

1287 The Genoese defeat Venetian fleet off Acre